

693JJ926RQ000003- NHTSA Vehicle Safety Hotline

SECTION C – DESCRIPTION/ SPECIFICATIONS/ WORK STATEMENT (DRAFT)

C.1 Overview/Background

C.1.1 Overview

The National Highway Traffic Safety Administration (NHTSA) is an agency within the U.S. Department of Transportation (DOT) whose primary mission is to save lives, prevent injuries, and reduce economic costs due to road traffic crashes, through education, research, safety standards, and enforcement. This is accomplished by:

- Setting and enforcing national safety performance standards for motor vehicles and equipment
- Educating the public to drive, ride and walk safely
- Promoting safety information and marketing campaigns to various audiences aimed at raising awareness and influencing and sustaining positive traffic safety behaviors

In 2024, NHTSA managed more than 1,000 safety recalls affecting more than 35 million vehicles and other automotive equipment. Many consumers call, email or chat NHTSA to get more information on these recalls

In 2025, NHTSA crash tested vehicles to determine safety ratings for approximately 87 percent of the new vehicle fleet. Many consumers call, email or chat NHTSA to learn more about these safety ratings.

A NHTSA study found that while most parents and caregivers believe they know how to correctly install their car seats, about half (46%) have installed their child's car seat incorrectly. Parents and caregivers call, email and chat NHTSA with questions about car seats.

C.1.2 Background

The National Highway Traffic Safety Administration's (NHTSA) Vehicle Safety Hotline (Hotline) is the agency's primary point of contact for the public to request safety defect information on passenger vehicles, heavy trucks, and recreational vehicle, or to report problems with motor vehicle equipment (e.g., air bags, motorcycle helmets, brakes, or child safety seats) that could affect safety. NHTSA evaluates the information gathered from the Hotline and from other sources to determine if serious safety problems exist.

The Hotline has undergone a major transformation from an operation that merely recorded vehicle-related complaints to a one-stop customer-oriented operation that accepts many types of calls related to vehicle and traffic safety. The major actions undertaken to transform Hotline operations include:

- Establishing the Hotline as the NHTSA's single point of public contact for safety information,
- Developing a training program that will assist the agents in obtaining vital information from consumers who would like file a vehicle safety complaint,
- Developing, publishing, and monitoring customer service standards (courtesy, timeliness,

and accuracy) as performance measurements.

- Publicizing the Hotline number during all NHTSA events,
- Expanding the Hotline's infrastructure to handle calls in English and Spanish; and
- Expanding Hotline services to include a web chat and automatic call back services.

Consumers may call a toll-free number to speak with a Hotline representative between the hours of 8:00 AM and 8:00 PM, ET, Monday through Friday. Callers may leave a message at times Hotline Representatives are unavailable. Consumers may also interact with Hotline representatives by email or web chat at www.nhtsa.gov. Based on the type of request, Hotline Representatives respond to calls instantaneously or typically the next business day.

C.1.2.1 Hotline Contact Type and Volume¹

The Hotline consumer engage for years 2022 through 2024 follows.

- Calendar year 2022:
 - Received 133,288 calls
 - Documented 12,361 E-VOQ's (Electronic Vehicle Owners Questionnaire)
 - Received 11,160 emails
 - Received 11,015 request to chat live
 - Received 23,627 automatic call back request
- Calendar year 2023:
 - Received 115,060 calls,
 - Documented 14,725 E-VOQ's
 - Received 14,305 emails
 - Received 11,279 request to chat live
 - Received 17,391 automatic call back requests
- Calendar year 2024:
 - Received 140,281 calls
 - Documented 17,596 E-VOQ's
 - Received 12,685 emails
 - Received 10,090 request to chat live
 - Received 29,874 automatic call back request

Between 2022 and 2024, the VSH experienced a 5 percent increase in call volume, 42 percent increase in VOQ complaints and 26 percent increase in Callbacks. This increase in volume was due to complex recalls involving vehicle fires for which parts were not available.

The Hotline handled an average of 11,000 calls, 1,241 VOQ complaints, 1,059 emails and 900 chats monthly.

¹ The above call volume represents the Hotline's most recent call volume history, and it is not an estimation of future call volume. Call volumes vary and are subject to fluctuation. NHTSA is conducting marketing activities that could increase call volume.

The increase in volume was due to several vehicle recall activities. Since 2022, the NHTSA Hotline has experienced significant surges in contact (calls, emails, and voicemails) volumes are due to recalls outlined below:²

- Recalls for over 7 million vehicles with “park away from structures” warnings due to risk of fires.
- Recall for over 2.5 million vehicles because the fuel pump inside the fuel tank may fail.
- Recall of nearly 3 million vehicles Because the bushing that attaches the shifter cable to the transmission may degrade or detach.
- Recall for over 1.2 million vehicles due to a software malfunction.

C.2 OBJECTIVE

The primary objectives is to obtain agency mission-critical information from callers about vehicle or vehicle equipment problems that may warrant a formal safety defect investigation; record complaint data on possible safety-related vehicle problems; provide answers to consumer questions related to vehicle and traffic safety issues; perform call-backs from recorded messages; fulfill information requests; electronically mail information to NHTSA action program offices on issues related to highway safety; refer calls to other non-safety related offices outside NHTSA (e.g. Environmental Protection Agency); and to provide general information in order to increase consumer understanding and awareness of issues concerning highway safety.

The Contractor shall be responsible for a *turnkey* Hotline call center operation to include all the necessary equipment, personnel, location, and managing of workflow.

C.3 Background Check Requirement/Access to Sensitive Information³

When Contractor employees have access to government facilities and/or sensitive information, including proprietary data and/or resources, the following must be met:

- Performance under this agreement may involve access to sensitive information which shall not be disclosed by the Contractor’s or any subcontractor’s employees assigned to this Task Order unless authorized by the Contracting Officer.
- The Contractor shall submit the names of all employees who will need to access any government systems.
- To protect sensitive information, the Contractor shall ensure training is provided to any employee authorized access to sensitive information and, upon request of the Government, provide information as to an individuals' suitability to have such authorization.
- Contractor or subcontractor employees found by the Government unsuitable or whose employment is deemed contrary to the public interest or inconsistent with the best interest of national security, may be prevented from performing work under the Task Order when requested by the Contracting Officer.

² This serves as an example of the possibility of an increased fluctuation in call volume that is based on agency initiatives and programs

³ Sensitive information is proprietary data or other information that, if subject to unauthorized access, modification, loss or misuse could adversely affect national interest, conduct of Federal programs, or privacy of individuals specified in the Privacy Act, but has not been specifically authorized to be kept secret in the interest of national defense or foreign policy under an Executive Order or Act of Congress.

The Contractor shall ensure that Contractor employees are:

- 1) citizens of the United States of America or
- 2) an alien who has been lawfully admitted for permanent residence or employment (indicated by immigration status) as evidenced by investigations in accordance with DOT Order 1632.2, Personnel Security Management.

The Contractor shall include the above requirements in any subcontract awarded involving access to Government facilities, sensitive information, and/or resources.

C.4 General Requirements

The Contractor shall provide facility, equipment, and personnel with the necessary expertise to operate an industry-standard hotline call center that serves as the central point of contact for the public, including Spanish speakers, to obtain and/or report information pertaining to motor vehicle and highway safety. The scope is to provide a fully hosted call center with the tools, technologies, equipment, security, personnel, and supervision to fulfill the requirements.

The primary purpose of the Hotline shall be to receive and respond to complaints from consumers on possible safety defects in motor vehicles and/or motor vehicle equipment (e.g., child safety seats, tires, and aftermarket parts). The call center will maintain toll free numbers and will also respond to inquiries received by email and through a web address and can host live web chats. Hotline inquiries and requests pertain to motor vehicles of all types – heavy trucks, (buses), RVs, and more familiar passenger vehicles such as SUVs, pickup trucks, minivans, and passenger cars.

Proper and timely processing of consumer complaints is critical to the success of the Hotline and is instrumental in NHTSA's investigations into alleged safety defects. The Contractor shall be responsible for ensuring that all complaints and material requests submitted through the Hotline are documented in an effective and time-efficient manner. All information documented through the Hotline facility shall be accurate, coherent, and grammatically correct (as outlined within the Performance Metric). Hotline operators shall interview callers seeking to report safety defects by requesting specific characteristics and symptoms associated with their concern. This will entail the use of multiple probing questions and appropriate automotive terminology to gather the maximum amount of detail possible. The Contractor shall be responsible for responding to call e-mails and web chats from the public regarding vehicle and traffic safety issues. In the event of an agency, departmental or national emergency, the Hotline may be required to serve as a central point of contact for NHTSA and/or DOT personnel to provide general operational information.

This will be a turnkey operation, i.e., the Contractor shall be responsible for the establishment, daily operations, and maintenance of the call center. Furthermore, the Contractor shall provide all the requisite personnel, hardware, operational software, telecommunications, site, equipment, maintenance, statistics, reports, business processes, and overall expertise to run the day-to-day operations of the Hotline in an efficient and cost-effective manner. The Contractor shall also provide reliable network up-time while providing high-quality service to consumers and the Government.

C.5 Definitions/Acronyms

The following is a list of key definitions and acronyms used throughout this agreement. This list may not be exhaustive.

C.5.1 Definitions

- 1) **Advanced Retrieval, Tire, Equipment, Motor Vehicles, Information System (ARTEMIS)** Advanced Retrieval, Tire, Equipment, Motor Vehicles, Information System is a Government- owned system that provides capabilities to capture, store, search, and analyze motor vehicle safety-related information submitted as a result of NHTSA implementation of statutory regulations to identify safety defects in vehicle/equipment components.
- 2) **Electronic Vehicle Owner Questionnaires (E-VOQ)**
An online data entry screen that Hotline employees use to capture data provided by the public about motor vehicle safety. Information entered on the screen resides in the Government-owned ARTEMIS system under NHTSA management.
- 3) **Vehicle Safety Hotline**
Department of Transportation (DOT) Vehicle Safety Hotline is a call-center operated in support of and managed by the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration.

C.5.2 Acronyms

The follow acronyms may be found in this Task Order. This list may not be exhaustive.

ACD	Automatic Call Distribution
ACOR	Alternate Contracting Officer's Representative
ARTEMIS	Advanced Retrieval, Tire, Equipment, Motor Vehicles, Information System
CAP	Contractor Acquired Property
CO	Contracting Officer
COR	Contracting Officer's Representative
DOT	Department of Transportation
EPA	Environmental Protection Agency
E-VOQ	Electronic Vehicle Owners Questionnaire
FAQ	Frequently Asked Question
GED	General Education Development Certificate
GFP	Government Furnished Property
IVR	Interactive Voice Response
ISA	Interconnection Security Agreement
KMD	Knowledge Management Database
NIST	National Institute of Standards and Technology
NHTSA	National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
OCCI	Office of Communications and Consumer Information
ODI	Office of Defects Investigation
OMB	Office of Management and Budget
QASP	Performance-Based Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan
QC	Quality Control
SUV	Sport Utility Vehicle

SOW	Statement of Work
VSH	Vehicle Safety Hotline
VIN	Vehicle Identification Number
VOQ	Vehicle Owners Questionnaire
VPN	Virtual Private Network

C.6 Specific Requirements

Task C.6.1 – Kick-Off Meeting

The kick-off meeting shall be held within four weeks after award for the Contractor staff, Contracting Officer, COR, Project Manager and implementation team. This meeting is to discuss any contractual matters and to define plans and expectations.

The kick-off meeting shall be held at the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration in Washington, DC, and shall be no more than a half-day in duration. In the event an in-person meeting is not feasible; a virtual meeting shall be required.

Task C.6.2 – Phase-In Transition

The phase-in transition will begin within two days of the kick-off meeting. The Government has allotted 90 days for the Contractor to transition from the incumbent Contractor. At the end of this period, the succeeding Contractor shall be fully operational.

The first 30 days of the transition shall be dedicated to the following task and activities;

- Introduction of Government and Contractor Staff
- Identifying transition team roles and responsibilities
- Security clearance process briefing
- Submit leadership and core staff security clearance documents
- NHTSA's technical expert's program overview sessions

The following 60 days of the phase-in transition shall be dedicated to communicating and exchanging knowledge with the incumbent Contractor. The COR will schedule a meeting with both Contractors to coordinate the transfer of services and information. During this period of the transition, the Contractor shall:

- Meet with COR and incumbent Contractor and develop an agreed upon delivery schedule
- Gain an understanding of the current call handling process by scheduling at least two shadowing sessions with the incumbent Contractor
 - Transfer all NHTSA owned phone numbers
 - Receive knowledge base and ticketing system data
 - Receive NHTSA SOP's, call flow charts and FAQ's

The COR will work closely with both Contractors to ensure that the appropriate communication is occurring and that deadlines are being met.

Task C.6.3 – Vehicle Safety Hotline IT Requirements and Services

The Government will provide computers/GFP that shall be used to document Electronic Vehicle Owners Questionnaire's (E-VOQ), and for uploading associated files and attachments in the Advanced Retrieval, Tire, Equipment, Motor Vehicle Information System (ARTEMIS). The Government will provide IT maintenance and support for issued GFP via Government IT helpdesk and ARTEMIS support team.

The Contractor shall provide and maintain all necessary IT equipment and IT services to support the call center call handling systems including the appropriate hardware and software and will immediately report any problems to the COR that cause or could potentially cause service disruptions.

The Contractor shall provide and maintain telecommunication systems capable of providing enterprise call center routing, ACD, call monitoring, recording of call data, and supports solutions for routing and agent selection, multi-site, remote agents, work force management, desktop applications, and system recovery. The Contractor shall provide real time and historic statistical reporting on Hotline activities. The Contractor shall provide all hardware and software maintenance of the telecommunication environment used in support of the Hotline throughout the life of the agreement.

The Contractor shall implement and maintain multiple communication channels to include toll free numbers, TTY/TTD, email, and web chat and automatic call back technologies to host inbound and outbound interactions with the Hotline customers. The Contractor shall ensure provisioning and maintenance of optimal data/voice bandwidth capacity to support the Hotline.

The Contractor shall make available a customer survey regarding satisfaction with the services provided to all customers who have contacted the Hotline. The customer survey results must be directly accessible by secure web access to the COR. The Contractor shall ask every caller for their email address so that a customer service survey can be emailed to the caller at the completion of the case/call. Survey monkey is the current survey system that is being used. The current process requires that the Contractor input the callers email address into the ticketing system so that when the call/case is complete the customer service survey is generated and emailed to the caller.

The Contractor shall provide a Web-based automated ticket tracking system to log complaints and inquiries and communicate with customers. This automated ticketing solution must be capable of processing data received via phone calls, emails, and web chats; should be capable of interpreting contacts received via e-mail or web form and provide an automated acknowledgement reply to the customer. Contractor shall develop and maintain a knowledge base and the ticketing system must have automated access to NHTSA-approved FAQs via the knowledge base system. The ticket tracking system shall be continuously available to provide remote monitoring to the COR or designee via secure web access.

The Contractor shall provide IT support for the timely and accurate processing, updating, and validating of vehicle safety complaints into ARTEMIS system. The Contractor shall provide data and system related troubleshooting support and software/system analysis support to the Hotline.

The Contractor shall provide overall facility management and maintenance of IT hardware and operating system software for a variety of hardware platforms such as telecommunications, help desk tracking system, servers, printers, software systems and desktop computing environment used to support the Hotline. This facility management and maintenance shall involve but not be limited to ongoing activity in the areas of installing, configuring, automated monitoring, maintenance/upgrade, troubleshooting, and the general administration of all system level hardware and software hosted and maintained by the Contractor shall support this Task Order.

Task C.6.4 – Contacts Received and Response

The Hotline will receive contacts from the public in the form of voice conversations with callers, voice recordings, e-mails, webchat, or specific requests from the COR. The Contractor shall respond to requests for a wide range of motor vehicle and highway safety information such as, but not limited to, motor vehicle safety defects and recalls, child safety seats, air bags, crash test results, and other general information regarding highway safety. The Contractor shall maintain a log of all contacts by type (e.g., inbound call, outbound call, e-mail, and webchat). The Contractor shall document the time, date, and subject matter of each contact made on NHTSA's behalf.

C.6.4.1 Incoming Calls

Automated Reception and Greeting

The Contractor shall develop two scripts that will be heard when callers reach the Hotline during business hours and non-business hours. One script shall be written to guide callers to the appropriate staff and/or queue based on their request using a numeric system. For example, a caller wishing to file a complaint would select option two. This selection will guide the caller to an operator prepared to fill out an E-VOQ.

There should be no more than six options for the caller to select. The opening script shall also inform callers that all calls are being recorded. In the event of high call volume during normal business hours, the Contractor shall offer the consumer the option of receiving an automatic callback without losing their place in line.

The second script shall inform callers that the Hotline is closed. This script shall be played during non-business hours and shall include an option for callers to leave a message. The Contractor shall return the call on the next business day. NHTSA shall approve the scripts before becoming operational.

The Contractor shall ensure that the script developed for the automated system informs callers who are on hold and/or who call during non-business hours about the NHTSA web site, www.nhtsa.gov as a source for information.

In addition to the requirement to make available a customer satisfaction survey identified in *Task C.6.3, Vehicle Safety Hotline IT-Requirements and Services*. The Contractor shall use a ticketing system that will allow this process to continue. The COR shall have all access to the survey username and password.

Hotline Representatives Contact with Callers

The Contractor shall develop a standard call flow chart and script that is consistently used by all staff accepting and receiving calls on NHTSA's behalf. The call flow chart shall reflect the order of communication from the beginning of a call to the end of a call. The script should

include a courtesy greeting, a question that asks callers what assistance they need, and a close-out statement based on call type. Scripts shall also include notations for all operators to identify themselves by name and to ask all callers if they would like to file a possible safety-related complaint on a vehicle or item of motor vehicle equipment. If the caller chooses to file a complaint, the Hotline representative shall record the complaint as an E-VOQ.

The Contractor shall develop standard scripts that address the NHTSA's Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) with a standard response. NHTSA will provide resources to assist in the development of FAQs. The Contractor shall use this information as the primary resource to respond to callers who call the Hotline. The current and initial baseline FAQ database will be transferred from the current Contractor during the transition phase. NHTSA shall approve the scripts before becoming operational.

Call Referral

The Contractor shall be responsible for referring calls to the proper Government organization or personnel when appropriate.

The Contractor shall refer calls to NHTSA subject matter experts only if deemed necessary by the on-site Contractor supervisor. The Contractor shall contact appropriate NHTSA subject matter experts using e-mail to provide caller information, phone numbers, and the nature of the information request. The Contractor shall copy the COR on referrals on e-mails sent to subject matter experts.

When a caller's inquiry is unrelated to vehicle safety, the caller will be referred by the Contractor's Hotline representatives to the appropriate Government agency. Current telephone numbers being used by Hotline representatives include, but are not limited to:

- Federal Trade Commission (202-326-2222)
- Consumer Product Safety Commission (800-638-2772)
- Environmental Protection Agency (EPA), 202-564-4700)

Telephone numbers are subject to change. The Contractor shall update referral telephone numbers quarterly.

C.6.4.2 Outgoing Calls

Recorded Messages

The Contractor shall be responsible for returning messages left on voicemail requiring a call back. Callers may leave messages during hours when

- Hotline representatives are unavailable,
- During peak hours when representatives' workloads prevent callers from reaching a representative through the Automatic Call Distribution (ACD) or equivalent system; and/or
- Callers choose to leave a recorded message to request information.

At a minimum, the Contractor shall return all calls no later than the next business day. The Contractor shall track the number of callbacks placed and record results.

The Contractor shall maintain and develop a call back log for each call. The call back log shall include the Hotline Representative's name, date, time of call, consumer's name and telephone

number, and the purpose of the call. The Contractor shall make three call back attempts. The Contractor shall make these three attempts within the next business day after consumer's call occurred.

On all call backs, the Contractor shall ask if the consumer wishes to file a possible safety-related complaint on a vehicle or item of motor vehicle equipment. The Contractor shall file safety-related complaint information on a vehicle or item of motor vehicle equipment as an E-VOQ database record.

C.6.4.3 Emails Received and Response

Emails Received

The Contractor shall respond to e-mail requests received through the NHTSA web site. When a consumer enters, and submits a request on the NHTSA web site, the request is delivered to the NHTSA webmaster account at nhtsa.webmaster@dot.gov. When e-mail is received at the webmaster account, it shall be automatically forwarded to the Hotline Contractor. The "NHTSA Webmaster" will submit your automated response (e.g. "Your email has been received by NHTSA and will be responded to the close of the next business day).

Email Response

The Contractor shall review and respond to all incoming e-mails that are forwarded. The Contractor shall use the Knowledge Management Database (KMD) of FAQs to accurately respond to e-mail inquiries. E-mails that are of a routine nature shall be responded to within the close of business of the next business day from the time the message was received. The Contractor's on-site supervisor shall use their discretion and their knowledge of agency programs and events to determine the urgency of request. The Contractor shall forward all urgent requests directly to the COR.

The Contractor shall develop an e-mail response script that will serve as a response to subject specific e-mails that are not in the KMD and need to be escalated to a higher level within NHTSA. The e-mail response script will acknowledge receipt of the consumers request and inform the consumer that a subject matter expert will respond to the request. The on-site Contractor supervisor shall forward to the COR and the subject matter expert all necessary escalations for information request. The Contractor shall copy the COR on all correspondence with agency subject matter experts.

C.6.4.4 Web Chats Received and Response

The Contractor shall provide a webchat service that will provide consumers that visit the NHTSA website the option of live engagement with a live customer service agent by clicking on the "Live Chat," icon that is housed on the [NHTSA.gov](https://www.nhtsa.gov) website. The Office of the Secretary, Chief Information Officer's office must approve the chat platform. The agent shall use the NHTSA approved FAQ's to respond to respond to web chat inquiries.

Task C.6.5 – Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ) Knowledge Management Database (KMD)

The Knowledge Management Database (KMD) allows for all *frequently asked questions* (FAQs) to be answered consistently among all Hotline representatives. The Contractor shall be responsible for maintaining and updating the existing KMD. The Contractor shall include the NHTSA subject matter expert referral as a part of the FAQ database. When necessary, the COR will provide the Contractor with a script and/or FAQ to respond to new NHTSA programs and

initiatives.

The KMD must be in Oracle or SQL. The Contractor shall provide the COR access to the KMD. NHTSA will approve all updates to the KMD.

The following are examples of commonly used FAQs:

A Defect Inquiry

FAQ: What is a safety defect?

Solution:

A safety-related defect is a problem that exists in a motor vehicle or item of motor vehicle equipment that:

1. Poses a risk to motor vehicle safety, and
2. May exist in a group of vehicles of the same design or manufacturer, or items of equipment of the same type and manufacturer.

Complaint Inquiry

FAQ: How am I alerted that NHTSA has my complaint?

Solution:

The Office of Defects Investigation will send you a copy of your complaint by email or postal mail within the next two weeks. Enclosed with the complaint will be a letter providing directives on how to update or provide additional information (e.g., copies of repair invoices, police report where a crash occurred, fire department report when a fire occurred, or more detailed information about the incident(s) relating to motor vehicle safety). Please attach the additional information to the enclosed Vehicle Owner's Questionnaire (VOQ). The information you provide will be used to update your report.

The Contractor shall produce and maintain a NHTSA-approved, up-to-date referral list based on information provided by Government sources such as the Web sites and NHTSA contact lists.

Task C.6.6 – Recall Information

The Contractor shall provide recall information to callers who have questions regarding vehicle, child seat and vehicle equipment recalls. The Hotline Representative shall use NHTSA-approved FAQ's to advise callers of the recall process. If the caller queries the Hotline Representative on the possibility of a safety recall for their vehicle, the Hotline Representative shall request that the caller provide their license plate number or 17-character Vehicle Identification Number (VIN).

Once the information is provided, the Hotline Representative shall research the vehicle using the license plate number or VIN look-up tool on the NHTSA website. The Hotline Representative shall provide the caller with the results of the search. If the vehicle has a safety recall, the Hotline Representative shall direct the caller to their local dealer or the manufacturer for repair.

The COR will send the Contractor notice for upcoming recalls and will alert the Contractor of recalls that are large in scope or are likely to cause an increase in call volume.

The Hotline Representative shall recommend that callers download NHTSA's SaferCar app or sign-up to receive recall email alerts on their vehicle. If the caller agrees to email alerts, the Hotline Representative shall register the consumer.

Task C.6.7 – Electronic Vehicle Owners Questionnaire (E-VOQ)

The primary purpose of the Hotline shall be to receive and process complaints from complainants, or other parties reporting on behalf of a complainant, concerning alleged safety related defects in motor vehicle and motor vehicle equipment in a manner that ensures NHTSA:

- 1) understands the basic facts and circumstances surrounding the safety problem, or incident the complainant experienced
- 2) the consequence or outcome of the incident that occurred as a result; and
- 3) what in the complainants' opinion was the cause of the incident, or the safety concern that prompted their contact to NHTSA.

When recording an E-VOQ, data accuracy and detail, as reported by the complainant or its representative, are the most important aspects of the Contractor's Hotline Representatives' duties. It is imperative that the Contractor obtain accurate contact information from callers including phone number, address and email address. Complainants should be advised that Office of Defects Investigation (ODI) Investigators may use their contact information to follow-up with consumers regarding their specific complaint.

The Contractor shall query all callers who speak to a Hotline Representative about experiencing a possible safety-related vehicle problem, or incident, and ask if they wish to file an E-VOQ. Once the caller indicates a desire to file an E-VOQ, the Hotline Representative shall immediately take the complaint using a script developed with input and concurrence from NHTSA. The Hotline staff should only refer complainants to the online VOQ under unique and rare circumstances, as E-VOQ's along with the audio recording are often very helpful to ODI staff.

The Contractor shall accurately record all E-VOQs in the most time-efficient and effective manner possible in accordance with NHTSA requirements detailed in this Contract. The Contractor shall enter and submit all E-VOQs to NHTSA's Advanced Retrieval, Tire, Equipment, Motor Vehicles, and Information System (ARTEMIS). The Contractor shall work with NHTSA technical personnel as required to establish connectivity to NHTSA's ARTEMIS for the Contractor to input motor vehicle safety information from the public. (See C.5.1)

The Contractor shall ensure that all E-VOQs meet the criteria as stated in the performance metric, as prescribed in Section F.5. The Contractor shall save and upload in Artemis the recorded audio file for all E-VOQ's within one working day of receipt. Each audio file shall be labeled with the associated E-VOQ reference number.

Consistent with the circumstances of the type of incident being reported, the Contractor shall query all callers that file a E-VOQ regarding the availability of additional, pertinent information and documents. For instance, in the case of a crash incident, the Contractor shall request photos of the crash damage, a police report, video files, etc. NHTSA will provide the Contractor with a list of pertinent documents to request based on the type of incident being reported. The Contractor shall provide the caller with instruction for submitting the documents both electronically to VSH@dot.gov, and in hard copy, at the caller's discretion.

The E-VOQs will be maintained online through an interface to NHTSA's ARTEMIS. The Contractor shall maintain a record of the total number of E-VOQs processed by the Hotline representatives per day, and by ODI Reference number.

The Contractor shall ensure that all Hotline Representatives translate the complainant's commentary into an accurate, understandable description that provides the required information

to NHTSA investigators. The Hotline Representative should take a passive posture when interviewing complainants, refraining from leading callers, offering suggestions or wording, or embellishing the information the caller is providing. To accomplish this, the Hotline Representative should use cognitive interviewing techniques, such as asking probing questions to clarify specific details, encouraging the complainant to think critically, and allowing the caller to speak fully and without interruption, interjection, or objection to the information being provided. NHTSA may provide examples of appropriate questions and may provide a script for documenting certain complaint types of specific incidents (e.g., a crash incident where the safety concern is the air bags failed to deploy). NHTSA may provide the same materials about certain types of defect issues, or in connection with ongoing investigative matters where specific detailed information is required by investigative staff.

The Hotline Representative shall explain to the caller that to conduct its safety mission, NHTSA may share the complaint, including their VIN, name, and contact information, with the vehicle manufacturer. The Hotline Representative shall also explain to the caller that sharing this information is optional and shall request consent from the caller. The Hotline Representative should document the E-VOQ appropriately based on the callers' response.

The Contractor shall immediately alert the COR regarding any technical issues with the E-VOQ form.

Any consistent problems in the areas addressed in the performance metric that occur throughout the term of the agreement will be documented by the COR and will be included in the *Past Performance Questionnaire for the Contractor*.

Task C.6.8 – Staffing Requirements

The Contractor shall provide personnel with the requisite skills to staff fully and manage the Hotline. Contractor personnel, at a minimum, shall be able to screen calls; conduct research using available NHTSA information; navigate the NHTSA web site to retrieve information quickly; and transcribe information accurately and completely using E-VOQ. The Contractor shall also be responsible for training its personnel about substantive issues including defects; compliance investigation-related issues; recalls; introduction to vehicle systems; vehicle equipment; new technology; and vehicle nomenclature. Contractor personnel are also expected to speak to callers at a proficient level about motor vehicle safety and defect issues.

NHTSA will supplement the new Contractor's personnel general automotive knowledge by hosting a series of training sessions with Hotline representatives and other NHTSA staff. NHTSA technical offices may also assist the Contractor by providing background information and/or conducting training sessions as deemed appropriate by the COR.

The Contractor shall ensure that personnel used in performance of this Contract shall exhibit courteous and professional behavior always, possess strong interpersonal skills in both oral and written communications, and exhibit familiarity with automotive components, concepts and terminology.

Neither the Contractor nor any employee thereof shall divulge to any third party any information obtained from NHTSA or information concerning work performed, results obtained, or any other information about this Task Order without the prior written consent of the Contracting Officer (CO). Contractor personnel shall enter into a confidentiality agreement with NHTSA regarding the non-disclosure of information related to this agreement. The Contractor's employees

working directly under this Task Order shall be required to sign a non-disclosure form. Prior to award, the CO will provide the Contractor with a non-disclosure form. On the award's effective date, the Contractor shall provide the CO with an executed non-disclosure form for each employee and all system administrators or other staff with access to the data supporting this agreement. The Contractor shall be responsible for maintaining an updated non-disclosure form that includes the signatures of any new employees assigned to the agreement during the performance of the agreement.

Task C.6.10 – Hotline Representative Availability and Downtime

C.6.10.1 Hotline Representative Availability

The Contractor shall provide sufficient representatives for Hotline operations during the hours of 8:00 AM. to 8:00 PM ET, Monday through Friday. The Contractor shall schedule and provide supervisors and subordinate staff necessary to meet the requirements.

C.6.10.2 Downtime

The Contractor shall maintain continuous (i.e., 365 days a year, 7 days a week, 24 hours per day) operational service. The Contractor shall provide and maintain a recorded voice mail messaging system to receive calls during non-business hours and during business hours when Hotline representatives are unavailable. The Contractor shall take all necessary steps to prevent interruptions to all facets of the operations and to avoid the routing of calls to an "overflow" status, thus making the Hotline services unavailable. Reporting of downtime shall be included in the monthly report (see F.4.1).

Task C.6.11 – Facility

The Contractor shall provide the facility and perform the requested services within the continental United States. At a minimum, the Contractor shall identify the security and facility resources that will be used for Hotline operations.

Task C.6.12 – NHTSA Hotline 800 Telephone Numbers

The Contractor shall be responsible for transferring and maintaining the following Vehicle Safety Hotline telephone numbers from the previous Contractor no later than 60 days into the phase-in transition at which time the Contractor shall be fully operational:

1 800 424-9393
1 888 327-4236
1 844 723-8782
1 888 776-8344
TTY 1-888-275-9171

The Contractor shall be responsible for additional toll-free phone lines as directed by the COR. It is unknown if a new and/or additional number will increase call volume.

Task C.6.13 – Interaction with Government Systems

The Contractor shall work closely with ARTEMIS help desk staff to ensure a secure, seamless, network interface between the Hotline and ARTEMIS. The Contractor shall ensure that all connections are in place within 60 calendar days after award.

The Contractor shall work with NHTSA's Office of the Chief Information Officer to develop an Interconnection Security Agreement (ISA) based upon NIST 800-47 guidance. This guidance is consistent with the requirements specified in the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) Circular A-130, Appendix III, for system interconnection and information sharing.

The Contractor shall provide a description of how it will provide high availability to meet performance metrics.

Task C.6.14 – Quality Control Program

The Contractor shall identify goals, objectives, and what steps or procedures will be implemented to monitor Quality Control (QC) for products and services provided by the Contractor (e.g. E-VOQs, material request forms, and child safety seat registrations). The Contractor shall maintain an effective Quality Control Program to ensure that the agreement's tasks are performed efficiently, effectively, in accordance with agreements requirements. At a minimum, the QC program shall address the following:

- Identify and document procedures and controls that will be used under the Task Order, to include documentation and reporting of QC efforts.
- Document names, positions, and qualification of the person or persons who will be responsible for QC under this agreement.

Provide performance measurement metrics regarding:

- number of E-VOQs entered daily by each representative,
- conducting caller surveys regarding quality of service provided,
- monitoring telephone use for accountability, and
- assuring continuous quality improvement in service and technology.

Note: The COR has the option of reviewing the QC Program quarterly and will provide comments to the Contractor. The Contractor shall then update the approved QC plan, if necessary, within 10 calendar days after receiving the COR's comments.

Task C.6.15 – Training Program

The Contractor shall be responsible for all Hotline Representative training. Training shall include at a minimum, substantive issues (e.g., defects, compliance investigation-related issues, recalls) and introduction to vehicle systems, vehicle equipment, and vehicle nomenclature.

The COR will assist the Contractor with training by providing:

- Examples of quality E-VOQs,
- Clarity on what is pertinent information when submitting an E-VOQ,
- The “DOs and DON’Ts” for filing E-VOQs, and
- Answers to specific questions of the Contractor.

The Contractor shall develop and maintain a training program that will enhance the Hotline Representatives ability to ask probing questions when handling complaint calls.

The Contractor shall implement and maintain a training program for all Hotline positions for the duration of the agreement. The Contractor shall provide training for new personnel, as well as provide training as needed to refresh current employees’ knowledge performing under this agreement.

Task C.6.16 – Meetings

C.6.16.1 Weekly Status Meetings

The Contractor shall meet with the COR weekly either by teleconference, videoconference, or in-person to discuss the status of Hotline operations and contract-related matters.

The meeting shall occur on a business day at a time and location determined by the COR in consultation with the Contractor’s Project Manager. The COR and Contractor’s Project Manager will be the required meeting participants. Other NHTSA or Contractor staff may participate as needed.

C.6.16.2 Ad Hoc Meetings

The COR may request that the Contractor attend special meetings with NHTSA’s technical experts to discuss upcoming initiatives or to address program specific needs.

The meeting will be held on an as needed basis and will be either by teleconference, videoconference, or in-person.

Task C.6.17 Phase-out Transition Plan

Within 90 days of the end date of the period of performance the Contractor shall price out the Phase-out Transition Plan, on a *Time and Materials* basis, and provide such proposal costs to the COR for review and evaluation not later than 90 calendar days prior to the expiration date of the agreement, the Contracting Officer (CO) will provide the Contractor with a modification to the agreement to establish a transition plan and payment of phase-out costs.

This agreement provides services vital to NHTSA's overall mission; continuity without interruption must be maintained at a consistently high level. After the period of performance, the incumbent Contractor, with assistance from the COR, shall provide all necessary effort and assistance to the new Contractor in transitioning the Hotline operations so either the Government or another provider may continue these services without interruption.

The successor Contractor will require assistance from the incumbent Contractor, and the incumbent Contractor shall give its best efforts and cooperation to affect an orderly and efficient transition from its operation to the successor. The incumbent Contractor shall provide the Government a comprehensive Phase-Out Plan no later than 90 days prior to expiration of this agreement, unless otherwise directed by the Contracting Officer. The Phase-Out Plan shall include, at minimum, provisions for the incumbent Contractor to assist and coordinate with the Government and the successor in the transition of all functions to operate the Hotline without interruption.

The incumbent Contractor shall make available sufficient personnel to conduct a joint inventory, with the successor Contractor and Government representatives, of all files, records, equipment, etc., to ensure records are accurate and complete. Subject to the CO's approval, the transition plan shall specify a training program and a date for transferring responsibilities for each division of work described in the plan. The Contractor shall provide sufficient experienced personnel during the phase-out period to ensure that the services called for by this agreement are maintained at the required level of proficiency.

The Contractor shall use as many personnel as necessary to remain on the job to help the successor maintain the continuity and consistency of the services required by this Task Order. The Contractor also shall disclose necessary personnel records and allow the successor to conduct on-site interviews with these employees for those employees expressing an interest to continue under successor. If selected employees are agreeable to the change, the Contractor shall release them at a mutually agreeable date and negotiate transfer of their earned fringe benefits to the successor.

The transition phase-out plan shall address at a minimum:

- Communications with the successor to exchange knowledge and coordinate Hotline operations changeover,
- Transfer of system information including programming operations documents, user documentation, reporting data, and existing Hotline data files,
- Restoration of Hotline services to ensure continuity of services, and
- Infrastructure configuration (e.g. file security, servers).

Any data that belong to NHTSA at the end of the agreement/during agreement close-out shall be returned to NHTSA on external Government-owned media such as USB Storage device.

C.7 – Minimum Performance Requirements

- Not less than 96 percent of all calls should be answered by a representative within 10 seconds, at a minimum, by a voice answering system,
- Not less than 96 percent of all callers should be speaking directly to a Hotline Representative within 24 seconds;
- Callers shall immediately receive the option of receiving an automatic callback when call volume is high and all customer agents are unavailable. Callers should not lose their place in the queue.
- Not less than four percent abandonment rate;
- Not less than 84 percent agent availability;
- Not greater than 165 seconds (2:45) average talk time, or not greater than 15 minutes if entering data (e.g. E-VOQ)
- Not greater than 24 seconds hold time;
- Not less than 98 percent of messages left on voicemail called back by the close of the next business day; and
- Not more than two complaints a month about the service

C.8 – Performance Measurement and QASP Requirements

C.8.1 – Performance Surveillance Requirements

Performance surveillance methods for the duration of the agreement are hereby established. Performance surveillance is based on five categories:

- 1) Inbound and Outbound Calls
- 2) Overall Customer Service
- 3) Maintaining the Knowledge Management Database
- 4) E-mail Automated Response Message to Inquiries “Webmaster”
- 5) Downtime

Each measurement within each category contains two elements:

- 1) Minimum Performance Requirement:
- 2) A statement describing the required service in terms of output.

Surveillance Method

- 1) Defines surveillance methods or techniques for monitoring performance.

C.8.2– Surveillance Plan

The Government developed the Surveillance Plan pursuant to the requirements of this Task Order. The Surveillance Plan sets forth procedures and guidelines that the Government will use in monitoring the Contractor’s technical performance. The Government will furnish the

Surveillance Plan (see below) to the Contractor. After award, the Government reserves the right to make changes, as deemed necessary, to the Surveillance Plan during the performance period. The Government will notify the Contractor about the Surveillance Plan changes prior to implementation of any revised procedures or guidelines.

Specifically, the Performance Requirements and Method of Surveillance are as follows:

C.8.3 Inbound Calls “Choosing to Speak to a Hotline Representative” and Outbound “Calls Returned”

Inbound Calls “Choosing to Speak to A Hotline Representative And Outbound “Calls Returned”	
Minimum Performance Requirement	Surveillance Method
1) Availability 100 percent of the time service must be available 24 hours per day, 7 days per week. Callers wishing to speak to a Hotline Representative can do so between 8:00 AM and 8:00 PM, EST, Monday through Friday. Peak hours normally occur between 9:00 AM and 3:00 PM.	Review automated call distribution monthly through system data capture.
2) Minimize Hang-Ups/Abandonment Rate No more than 4 percent of callers wishing to speak to a Hotline Representative will be lost.	
3) Average Hold Time Average hold time shall not exceed 24 seconds.	
4) Answer Calls Promptly Answer calls promptly. Calls shall be in the queue” no longer than 24 seconds.	
5) Automatic Callback Callers shall immediately receive the option of receiving an automatic callback when call volume is high and all customer agents are unavailable. Callers should not lose their place in the queue.	

6) Voicemail Call Back At least 98% of messages left on voicemail called back by COB of the next business day.	
7) Average Talk Time Average talk time shall not exceed two minutes 45 seconds. If entering data (e.g. E-VOQ) then the average talk time shall not exceed 15 minutes.	
8) Request to File a Complaint 100 percent of the time Hotline Representatives are required to ask callers to file a complaint	

C.8.4 Overall Customer Service

Overall Customer Service	
Minimum Performance Requirement	Surveillance Method
1) Provide accurate and current responses tailored to the individual needs of each caller and to agency 100% of the time.	Random review of call recordings by the COR.
2) Each Hotline Representative must identify themselves (by name or assigned alias) to each caller.	
3) Provide courteous service.	

C.8.5 Maintain Knowledge Management Database

Maintain Knowledge Management Database	
Minimum Performance Requirement	Surveillance Method
1) Maintain a Knowledge Management Database of NHTSA programs and policies.	

2) Maintain an up-to-date referral list of subject matter experts within NHTSA.	Review 100 percent of FAQs for accuracy. Review any updates to the list
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C.8.6 E-mail Automated Response Message to Inquiries “Webmaster”

Email Automated Response Message to Inquiries “Webmaster”

Email Automated Response Message to Inquiries “Webmaster”	
Minimum Performance Requirement	Surveillance Method
1) The “NHTSA Webmaster” will submit an automated response (e.g. “Your e- mail has been received by NHTSA and will be responded to by close of business next business day. Please call (888-327-4236) if you need immediate assistance.”). The automated response will be submitted immediately upon receipt of an e-mail 100 percent of the time.	Customers and agency personnel reporting delays in receiving acknowledgments of and responses to emails sent through the NHTSA website.
2) 100 percent response rate to of all e-mail inquiries and/or escalated by the end of the next business day.	

C.8.7 Downtime

No Downtime during Operational Hours (Monday through Friday, 8:00 AM and 8:00 PM, ET., Eastern Standard Time)

Downtime	
Minimum Performance Requirement	Surveillance Method
1) Contractor maintains continuous infrastructure operational service without a substantial amount of downtime (i.e. 45 min. or longer) during operational hours.	Complaints from customers and agency personnel. Access to Contractor's infrastructure
2) Submit Downtime Reports within 60 minutes of occurrence.	Review Downtime Reports
3) The Contractor shall take all necessary steps to prevent significant downtime with <i>all</i> facets of the operations and avoid having calls routed to overflow or to the IVR more than 3 times per month.	Contractor's Downtime Prevention & Infrastructure plan will be reviewed.

C.9 Performance Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan (QASP)

NHTSA developed the Performance Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan (QASP) pursuant to the requirements of this agreement. The QASP sets forth procedures and guidelines that the Government will use in evaluating the Contractor's technical performance. NHTSA will furnish the plan so the Contractor is aware of the methods that the Government will use in evaluating performance under this agreement. After award, the Government reserves the right to revise, as deemed necessary, the QASP during the period of performance. The Government will notify the Contractor regarding QASP revisions prior to implementation of the revised procedures and guidelines. (Please see attached Performance Metric for specific criteria)

Specifically, the minimum Performance Standards are as follows:

C.9.1 EVOQ Quality

EVOQ Quality		
Performance Requirement	Minimum Performance Standard	Surveillance Method
1) Enter all E-VOQ's in the Artemis Database in the most time efficient and effective manner.	Average talk time for E-VOQ entry shall not take longer than 15 minutes. (C.7)	Random review of a selected sample of E-VOQ's submitted by the Contractor monthly the number of EVOQs will be based on the sampling size referenced in the attached performance metric sheet.
2) Each E-VOQ shall include a coding that identifies it as an E-VOQ submitted by the Contractor.	Report relevant and accurate data into E-VOQ. Ninety-five must meet the SOW Quality metric criteria as outlined in F.5 of the E-VOQs examined, based on attached performance metric sheet.	Returned E-VOQ to NHTSA with inaccurate data identified by the consumer
3) All information gathered shall be relevant, accurate and grammatically correct.		NHTSA's Office of Defects Investigation feedback on E-VOQ quality from

C.10 – Government-Furnished Documents

The COR will provide to the Contractor, upon request, the following items:

- 1) Sample training documentation for the Highway Traffic Safety Administration Vehicle Safety Hotline⁴
- 2) A Department of Transportation Contingency Plan template that outlines the type of information the Contractor may be asked to provide as part of the Disaster Recovery Plan deliverable. Additional information about the Hotline can be located at www.nhtsa.dot.gov/hotline.

C.11– Government- Furnished Items

C.11.1- Database Software

During the initial phase of the agreement, the COR will provide the Contractor access to an existing agency Web-based information database (ARTEMIS) to process a variety of electronic transactions. The database system is used to process E-VOQs, to enter and log vehicle complaints, to record the source from which the caller obtained the Hotline's toll-free telephone number, as well as to retrieve recall, crash tests results, defect investigation status, and other current or historical data. The Government will provide licenses to Virtual Private Network (VPN) client, VPN software, and any other software required connecting to ARTEMIS. The NHTSA Office of Defect Investigations' (ODI) ARTEMIS Help Desk will provide access to the database with technical assistance.

The management of information technology is filled with many challenges due to rapidly changing technologies, an increasing demand for electronic information and services, security issues, and the passage of new legislation. The body of policy and guidance that provides a framework for the DOT information technology program is contained in the Departmental Information Resource Management Manual (DIRMM), in accordance with NIST Standard 800-53.

C.11.2 – Use and Protection of Database

The ARTEMIS information database is a protected Government system of records, which is covered by the Privacy Act. The Contractor is prohibited from accessing or using the information database for any purpose other than as authorized under this Task Order.

⁴ The sample training documentation may be used at the Contractor's discretion as a starting point for developing instructional material for Hotline representatives.

C.12– Special Ad Hoc Hotline Assignment Tasks

Periodically, the Contractor shall be required to perform tasks not outlined in the original Statement of Work. Each such task will be characterized as Special Hotline Assignment Task. New project development shall be defined as needs are identified. Upon the identification of the need for such additional tasks by the COR, such tasks will be handled as Special Ad Hoc Hotline Assignment Tasks.

These tasks will be priced separately from this agreement. The Contracting Officer (CO) will negotiate with the Contractor prior to issuing the corresponding modification to the agreement for the Special Ad Hoc Hotline Assignment Task. Depending upon the nature of such Special Ad Hoc Hotline Assignment Task, the task may be negotiated on a firm fixed price (FFP), labor hour (LH), Time and Materials (T&M) basis, or a combination thereof.

At no time during the entire 60 month period of performance shall the amount of any Special Ad Hoc Hotline Assignment task exceed \$3.5 million dollars.

➤ Examples of past Special Ad Hoc Hotline Assignment Tasks:

- Adding and/or managing additional phone numbers and/or lines to service a new and/or unique agency initiative's is an example of an ad-hoc task that may be requested under this agreement. Scope and call volume varies on demand and is not predictable. The COR will work closely with the contractor to determine the need for additional resources.
- The most remarkable ad-hoc request was the *Car Allowance Rebate System (CARS)*, also known as *Cash for Clunkers*, hotline. In June 2009, the Contractor supported the CARS program that received up to 60,000 calls a day. The call center was in operation for approximately 5 months.
- The COR along with the program office staff provides and/or facilitates all the training and training documentation that is needed.

C.13 – Training

NHTSA may require the Contractor to participate in technical training events or courses to ensure efficiency in responding to inquiries, to include acquire specific technical expertise.

(End of Section C)